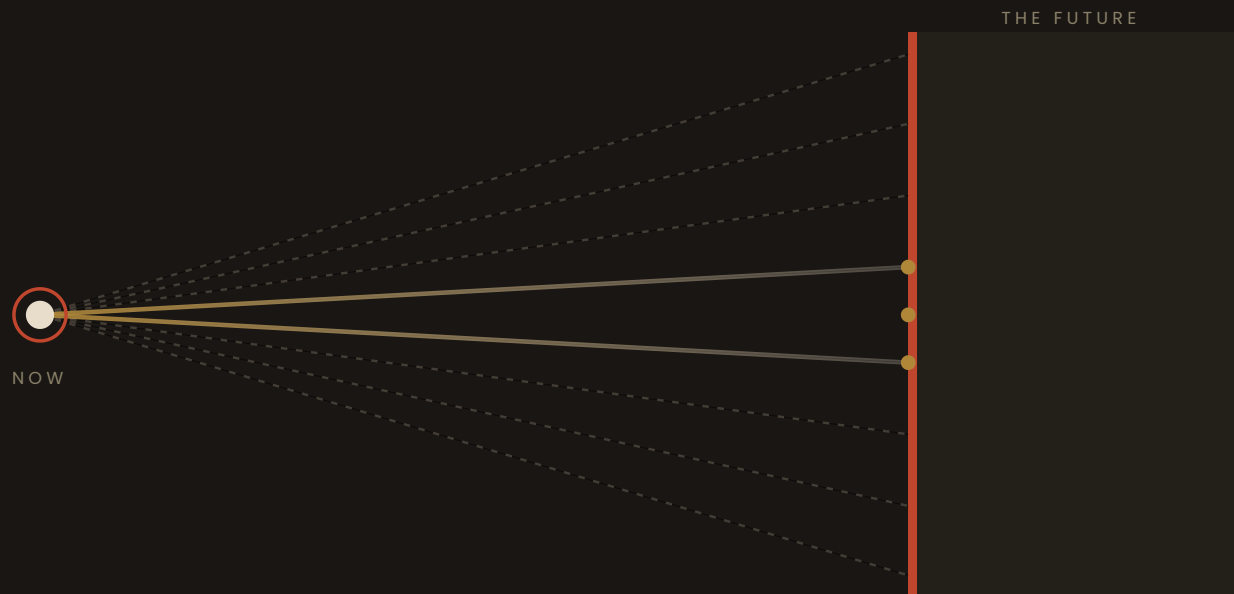


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



MOST OF WHAT WE PRICE, BOOK AND FEAR HAS NOT ARRIVED YET

THE WORLD

Yemen's Houthis put their Saudi blockade into force, and a war keeps concentrating onto the world's two thinnest sea lanes

TECHNOLOGY

For a few hours on Thursday, the most valuable company on Earth made phones, not chips — and the memory shortage found a price

SCREEN & SOUND

Half a billion people watched a trailer in a day for a film that opens ten months from now

THIS ISSUE

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p21–23 The Long Read — "Pricing the Unarrived"

FROM THE DESK

"It may be observed in general that the future is purchased by the present."

— Samuel Johnson, *The Rambler* No. 175 (19 November 1751)¹

It fits an issue thick with things that have not happened yet. Half a billion people watched a trailer for a film ten months away (p12). Markets spent the week pricing a Fed meeting that will not sit until the 28th (p15). Bidders staked S\$2.13 billion on Bedok land that will not house anyone for years (p6), and a war drove oil higher on the fear of a strait being closed rather than the fact of it (p3). The Long Read (p21) follows that habit back to Osaka's rice traders, the South Sea Bubble and the railway mania — three times a society tried to buy the future and learned what it had actually paid.

BRENT CRUDE

~\$91.1 ▲

GOLD (XAU)

\$4,098 ▲

BITCOIN

~\$66.3k ▲

USD/SGD

1.2912

US 10-YEAR

~4.60% ▲

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

Enforced: the Houthis' declared blockade of Saudi Arabia became a live convoy threat in the Bab el-Mandeb, the corridor carrying a tenth of world trade (p3).

Overtaken: Apple briefly passed Nvidia as the world's most valuable company on 17 July, before the chipmaker clawed most of it back (p7).

Named: Sushil Nair as Singapore's fifth Chief Justice, to take office in February 2027 (p5).

Repriced: the odds on a July Fed hike, swinging across a wide band into the 28–29 July meeting (p15).

STANDING NOTE

This issue runs as a straight news book, not a themed spine — no single motif is forced across all twelve desks. Only the Long Read (p21) argues one connected idea, deliberately: the habit of bending every desk toward a unifying theme shows its own machinery if run too often, and some weeks are better served by simply reporting them well. The thread it does pull — how much of the news is about things not yet arrived — is left where it belongs, in the essay.

SOURCES ¹ Samuel Johnson, *The Rambler* No. 175 (19 Nov 1751). Market strip: TradingEconomics, StockAnalysis.com, Fortune, CNBC — levels as of 20–21 Jul 2026, subject to change by press time; VWRA's last verified print (\$186.98, 19 Jul) is held on p15 rather than restated here.

THE WORLD · THE GULF WAR, DAY 29

The Houthi Blockade of Saudi Arabia Becomes Real

A declaration made last weekend hardened this week into convoy escorts and threatened shipping, as the Gulf war kept narrowing onto the two straits it cannot stop returning to.

The blockade Yemen's Houthis announced on 20 July is now something ships have to plan around. The movement said it would treat Saudi-bound traffic through the Bab el-Mandeb — the twenty-kilometre neck between the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden through which roughly a tenth of world trade physically passes — as fair game, in retaliation for a Saudi-led strike on Sanaa's airport.¹ A full closure of the strait would take an estimated 7% of global oil supply off the water on top of the disruption already flowing from the Gulf, and the Saudi-led coalition answered that it would respond "with force," beginning convoy-protection measures for its own vessels.²

The wider war did not pause to accommodate the new front. U.S. Central Command flew a tenth consecutive night of strikes into Tuesday, hitting what it described as Iranian command centres, missile and drone sites and air defences, and the small Gulf island of Greater Tunb; Iran, for its part, struck a tanker off the coast of Oman inside the Strait of Hormuz early on 21 July.³ Tehran's own tally since the 22 June talks window opened stands at 38 killed and more than 400 wounded — a figure Iran publishes and Washington does not confirm.⁴

~10%

OF WORLD TRADE PASSES THROUGH THE BAB EL-MANDEB STRAIT THE HOUTHIS ARE NOW THREATENING — THE SECOND OF THE TWO CHOKEPOINTS THIS WAR KEEPS RETURNING TO, AFTER HORMUZ.

Markets read the widening the way they always read a strait: on the fear, not the fact. Brent settled around \$91 on 21 July, up more than 2% on the day and roughly a fifth above where it began the month, with traders watching whether slower Hormuz traffic and the fresh Bab el-Mandeb threat together push it past \$100.⁵ Diplomacy is not dead so much as flickering: Iran's foreign ministry says mediators have carried "new proposals," while the 14 June memorandum meant to run a sixty-day path to a formal end is undercut by the July fighting it was supposed to prevent.⁶ See p15.

BLOCKADE

TWO STRAITS

OIL BID

DOHA

AL JAZEERA FRAMING

Al Jazeera frames the blockade as the predictable spillover of a war Washington and Israel are prosecuting against Iran, now landing on the Gulf monarchies rather than the belligerents. Its lead angle is the region as collateral — Gulf states quietly pressed to "diversify" their security away from a United States that flew a tenth night of strikes before any new front opened.⁷

TEHRAN

PRESS TV / IRNA FRAMING

Iranian state media casts the American campaign as a series of war crimes, citing strikes it says hit a mineral-water plant and a maritime traffic-control centre, and warns of a "full-scale offensive" if the bombing continues. The Foreign Ministry's line is that every Iranian action is defensive under Article 51, and that Washington voided the June memorandum first by keeping its naval blockade in place.⁸

BEIJING

CHINESE FRAMING

Chinese commentary positions Beijing as the adult in an overreaching room: cutting refinery runs and drawing down inventories rather than bidding up crude, and continuing to lift Iranian-approved oil — some of it escorted — bound for China and India. State outlets call the posture "objective and balanced"; Western analysts read it as China banking the war's side effects while paying none of its costs.⁹

SOURCES 1 NPR, "Houthis declare naval blockade of Saudi Arabia," 21 Jul 2026; The War Zone, 20 Jul 2026. 2 The War Zone / Daily Caller, 20 Jul 2026; NPR, 21 Jul 2026. 3 Just Security "Early Edition," 21 Jul 2026; CNN live coverage, 15–17 Jul 2026. 4 Al Jazeera, 17 Jul 2026 (Iranian Health Ministry figures; not independently confirmed). 5 TradingEconomics; Fortune, "Oil prices climb as Gulf war widens," 21 Jul 2026. 6 NPR, 21 Jul 2026; UK House of Commons Library briefing CBP-10637. 7 Al Jazeera analysis, 2 & 17 Jul 2026. 8 Press TV / IRNA via CNN live coverage, 13–17 Jul 2026. 9 Reuters / summary reporting on China's crude posture, Jul 2026.

KYIV'S WAR MINISTRY WAITS ON THE RADA

Ukraine's defence ministry has a strike commander in the acting chair and a date to make it permanent. Yevhen Khmara — formerly acting head of the SBU security service and, before that, commander of its Alpha special-operations unit and long-range strike programme — took over as acting defence minister when the decree took effect on 20 July, President Zelensky citing his "unprecedented experience in technology-driven strike operations."¹ Formal confirmation by the Verkhovna Rada, delayed by the chamber's summer recess, is now expected at its next plenary session on 18 August rather than this week — leaving Khmara to run wartime procurement and battlefield coordination for a month on an acting mandate.² This advances, rather than re-opens, the appointment first reported in No. 46–48.

CONGO'S EBOLA PASSES 930 DEATHS, STILL ACCELERATING

The Bundibugyo-strain outbreak declared in eastern Congo on 15 May is, by the WHO's own account, the fastest-spreading Ebola epidemic on record. The health ministry's count through 18 July put deaths at 930 out of 2,344 confirmed cases — with 40 deaths and 83 new cases logged in a single day — and most new infections now tracing to chains of transmission no one has mapped.³ Ituri province is worst hit (2,090 cases, 776 deaths); North Kivu accounts for most of the rest.⁴ The caveat to hold alongside the alarm, flagged in No. 46: researchers believe the Bundibugyo species may respond better to existing therapeutics than the more familiar Zaire strain, though nothing is yet approved for it specifically.

WASHINGTON

POLICY READ

The Canada tariff lands the same week the administration is trying to bankroll its Gulf posture with allied money rather than its own — Trump's short-lived 20% Hormuz "reimbursement" fee, shelved in No. 48 for Gulf-state investment pledges, set the template. The through-line critics draw: a foreign policy increasingly financed by tolls, tariffs and pledges, each announced as leverage and priced by markets as risk.⁸

A 50% TARIFF ON CANADA, AND TWO DISASTERS

Washington opened a second kind of front on 21 July, with President Trump announcing 50% tariffs on most Canadian goods — the sharpest escalation yet in a trade fight that had been simmering all summer, and one whose market read-through lands on p15.⁵ Elsewhere: in the Indian state of Sikkim, at least ten workers were killed and seventeen left missing after a hydropower-tunnel collapse blamed on a suspected gas blast; and the UN refugee agency said more than five hundred Rohingya were missing and feared drowned after boats capsized off Myanmar.⁶

"The costs are being paid by the neighbours — and they know it." — the Gulf's view of a war it did not start

IN BRIEF

Gaza: nine months into the October 2025 truce, Gaza's media office logs 1,122 Palestinians killed and 3,599 wounded in Israeli strikes since it took effect; Hamas has named Khalil al-Hayya its new leader. Neither side calls the truce void.⁷

Bab el-Mandeb: the corridor the Houthis are now threatening carries an estimated 12% of global trade (Al Jazeera) — which is why Riyadh, and shipping insurers, took the blockade declaration seriously rather than as rhetoric.

Still on the shelf: the World Cup final (Spain 1–0 Argentina, No. 47) stands as reported; only the deltas above are carried forward.

MUSCAT

MEDIATION

Oman remains the one open channel. Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi has again used Muscat to test whether anything of the suspended June framework can be salvaged, even as the strikes continue — the quiet diplomatic track that has outlasted every ceasefire announcement since the spring.⁹

SOURCES 1 Ukrinform, "Zelensky names Khmara acting Defense Minister," 16–20 Jul 2026. 2 Ukrinform / Ukrainska Pravda, 17–20 Jul 2026 (Rada session 18 Aug). 3 Washington Times, 20 Jul 2026; WHO Disease Outbreak News DON613. 4 ECDC communicable-disease threat report, through 19 Jul 2026. 5 Democracy Now / wire bulletins, 21 Jul 2026. 6 AFP / Yahoo News bulletins, 21 Jul 2026. 7 Al Jazeera; Democracy Now, 16–21 Jul 2026 (Gaza Government Media Office figures). 8 CNBC, 13–14 Jul 2026; Breitbart, 14 Jul 2026. 9 Fortune, 18 Jul 2026.

SINGAPORE

A New Chief Justice, Named Nineteen Months Ahead

Sushil Nair will succeed Sundaresh Menon in February 2027 — a long-lead succession announced the same week the government closed the book on a resigned minister's seat.

Singapore has its next Chief Justice, and an unusually long runway to get used to the idea. Justice Sushil Sukumaran Nair, 60, was named on 17 July to become the Republic's fifth Chief Justice with effect from 26 February 2027, the day the current CJ, Sundaresh Menon, reaches the retirement age and steps down.¹ Nair spent thirty-five years in practice — latterly as deputy chief executive of Drew & Napier — before joining the Bench in April 2025 and being elevated to the Court of Appeal only last month, on 15 June; the appointment vaults a relatively new judge over more senior colleagues, on the strength of a commercial-litigation reputation the legal fraternity has long regarded as first-rank.²

The announcement shared the week with the closing of a political chapter. Following Associate Professor Muhammad Faishal Ibrahim's resignation as minister and MP over a conduct lapse — reported in No. 48 — the government confirmed on 20 July that there will be no by-election to fill the vacancy in Marine Parade–Braddell Heights GRC, PAP chairman Desmond Lee noting the four remaining members will continue to serve the ward.³ The opposition Red Dot United publicly pressed for a by-election on 21 July; the constitutional position, as in past GRC vacancies, does not require one.⁴

+20.7%

JUNE NON-OIL DOMESTIC EXPORTS, Y/Y — A NINTH STRAIGHT MONTH OF GROWTH, BUT THE SLOWEST SINCE MARCH, UNDERSHOOTING A ~30% CONSENSUS AS THE AI-ELECTRONICS SURGE DID THE LIFTING.

The economy, meanwhile, is running warm on one cylinder. Non-oil domestic exports rose 20.7% in June, a ninth consecutive monthly gain but a sharp deceleration from May's 38.4%, with electronics up 105% on AI demand even as non-electronic shipments fell.⁵ Households are feeling the price side of that heat: a Singapore Management University survey published on 21 July found one-year-ahead inflation expectations edging up to 3.0% in June from 2.8% in March.⁶ The Monetary Authority's own July policy statement and Macroeconomic Review land on 27 July — after this edition — so any read on its next move is held, not guessed.⁷

JUDICIARY

NO BY-ELECTION

NODX

STILL ON THE SHELF

Bayshore Drive's record land bid, flagged unconfirmed in No. 48, is now confirmed — the full read is on p6.

The Auditor-General's MOH/MOHH follow-through (No. 48) is unchanged: recovery of the flagged overpayment is still due by December.

THE SCEPTIC

A nineteen-month notice period on a Chief Justice reads as stability, and mostly is — but it also means the courts spend a year and a half with a designated successor in the wings, a dynamic other jurisdictions have found awkward. Singapore's counter is that its judiciary treats the handover as administrative, not political; the long lead is a feature, giving the incoming CJ time to shape the roster he will inherit rather than a lame-duck interval.

SOURCES 1 Judiciary / PMO media release, 17 Jul 2026; Mothership, 17 Jul 2026. 2 The Straits Times / Mothership, 17 Jul 2026. 3 PMO Newsroom; Mothership, 20 Jul 2026. 4 The Online Citizen, 21 Jul 2026 (RDU statement). 5 Enterprise Singapore external-trade data, via TradingView, mid-Jul 2026. 6 SMU Newsroom, 21 Jul 2026. 7 MAS Advance Release Calendar; MAS MPS, 14 Apr 2026.

PROPERTY

Bedok's Record Bid, Now Confirmed

A Frasers-led consortium's S\$2.13 billion offer for the Bayshore Drive site is the top bid at tender close — Singapore's largest non-central land sale — while Turf City's first private condo opens its books this weekend.

The number flagged as unconfirmed in No. 48 has a name attached to it. A consortium of Frasers Property, Frasers Centrepoint Trust, Sunway MCL, Sekisui House and Lum Chang placed the top bid for the Bayshore Drive mixed-use plot at S\$1,323 per square foot per plot ratio — S\$2.13 billion in all, and 5.8% clear of the second-placed grouping led by Hong Leong and City Developments.¹ The tender closed on 15 July; the award remains subject to state approval, so it is still, strictly, the top bid rather than a done deal.² The site, near Bedok South MRT, is slated for about 1,280 homes and anchors the first private launch in the long-planned Bayshore precinct.

The developers are underwriting that price into a cooling private market. URA's Q2 flash estimate had all-residential prices up just 0.5% quarter-on-quarter, decelerating from 0.9%, and the number hides a split: the Core Central Region rose 2.0% while the Rest of Central fell 1.4% and the Outside Central Region slipped 0.2%.³ The HDB resale index, meanwhile, logged a second straight quarterly fall of 0.3% — the first back-to-back declines in nearly seven years.⁴ A record bid on Bedok land, in other words, is a bet on the precinct and the 2030s, not on this quarter's index.

S\$2.13bn

BAYSHORE DRIVE TOP BID — SINGAPORE'S LARGEST LAND SALE OUTSIDE THE CENTRAL AREA, 5.8% ABOVE THE RUNNER-UP, AWARD STILL PENDING STATE APPROVAL.

The nearer-term test is smaller and sooner. Dunearn House — 380 units in District 11, by Frasers Property with CSC Land and Sekisui House — opens sales on 25 July as the first private launch inside the Bukit Timah Turf City masterplan, priced from S\$1.475 million, or about S\$2,799 per square foot for a two-bedder.⁵ It follows Lentor Gardens Residences, which cleared roughly 54% of 499 units at about S\$2,350 psf over its 18–19 July opening (No. 48, now confirmed), and sits ahead of Amberwood at Holland and CDL's Lucerne Grand in the third-quarter pipeline.⁶

GLS

NEW LAUNCH

BIFURCATION

THE CHATTER

On the property forums the Bayshore bid is being read two ways: as a vote of confidence in a genuinely new coastal precinct, and as evidence that only the biggest consortia can now absorb a S\$2bn land bill plus 35% developer ABSD clearance risk. The recurring worry in the threads — that Turf City and Bayshore both price from the high-S\$2,000s while the resale index softens — is answered by the same posters noting that new-launch and resale have decoupled for two years now.⁷

IN BRIEF

En bloc: the collective-sale market stays subdued under the ABSD headwind, though freehold Serenity Park off Yio Chu Kang Road has launched at a S\$505m guide.⁸

BTO: no July exercise; the next tranche is October, the last of three 2026 rounds totalling about 19,600 flats.⁹

SOURCES 1 Yahoo Finance SG; EdgeProp, mid-Jul 2026. 2 World Construction Network; The Edge Singapore, Jul 2026. 3 URA Q2 flash estimate via 99.co / CBRE, 1 Jul 2026. 4 HDB flash estimate; Malay Mail, 1 Jul 2026. 5 The Edge Singapore; Stacked Homes; 99.co, Jul 2026. 6 99.co new-launch trackers, Jul 2026. 7 HardwareZone / EdgeProp property forums, Jul 2026 (forum sentiment). 8 EdgeProp en-bloc trackers, 2026. 9 HDB, 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY

For a Few Hours, the Biggest Company Made Phones

Apple briefly retook the market-cap crown from Nvidia as the AI-chip trade wobbled; the tungsten-gas squeeze found a price; and the next Nvidia platform entered full production even as its China sales stayed near zero.

The symbolic moment came on 17 July, when Nvidia shares fell about 3.9% at the open and Apple — on nothing more dramatic than steadiness — briefly reclaimed the title of the world's most valuable company, pushing Nvidia's market value down to roughly \$4.82 trillion before it clawed most of the loss back to around \$4.91 trillion by the close.¹ It is a small thing and a large one at once: the chipmaker that hit \$5.5 trillion in May, and passed \$5 trillion in No. 48, is now trading on the same doubts about "more compute" that tipped the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index into a bear market last week (p15).

Underneath the scoreboard, the machine keeps shipping. Nvidia confirmed its next platform, Vera Rubin, is in full production, with OpenAI, CoreWeave, Google Cloud, Azure and Meta all slated to deploy the NVL144 racks — eight AI exaflops and 100 terabytes of fast memory apiece — at scale in the third quarter, and the million-token-context "Rubin CPX" variant due by year-end.² The sovereignty gap sits right beside it: a U.S. Commerce official told Congress on 14 July that only a "trivial" number of H200 chips have actually shipped to China despite licences being approved — the export victory that keeps booking no revenue.³

~16x

REPORTED JUMP IN THE PRICE OF TUNGSTEN HEXAFLUORIDE (WF6) — FROM ROUGHLY 120,000 TO ABOUT 2 MILLION YUAN A TONNE — AFTER TWO JAPANESE SUPPLIERS PERMANENTLY HALTED OUTPUT (NO. 48). FIGURE VIA TRADE AGGREGATORS; TREAT AS INDICATIVE.

The chokepoint No. 48 opened has a number now, if a rough one. With the two Japanese makers of high-purity WF6 — the tungsten gas used to lay down chip interconnects — permanently offline after China's export curbs cut their raw material, trade outlets report the spot price spiking from about 120,000 yuan a tonne toward two million, and MOFCOM's tungsten, antimony and silver licensing rules now running through 2027 with credit thresholds designed to keep the material at home.⁴ Rare-earth "concept" stocks are up 200–350% on the year on the same logic.

And the models keep undercutting the hardware thesis that funds them. Alibaba previewed Qwen3.8-Max on 19 July — a 2.4-trillion-parameter multimodal model, open weights to follow, explicitly framed as chasing Moonshot's Kimi K3, whose full 2.8-trillion-parameter weights are due on 27 July; DeepSeek's V4 has already shipped with a million-token context and a peak/off-peak pricing scheme, and its legacy API aliases retire on 24 July as flagged.⁵ Each release makes frontier capability cheaper to run — which is exactly what the semiconductor tape is nervous about.

THE CHATTER

The analyst read on the Apple-over-Nvidia headline is that it measures sentiment, not fundamentals: Nvidia's order book is still the deepest in tech, and a one-day cap swap on a steadier Apple says more about how crowded the AI trade had become than about demand. The bear case the desks keep returning to is narrower — that open-weight models from Chinese labs compress the premium buyers will pay for the very top chip, not that they stop buying it.

CAP CROWN

VERA RUBIN

WF6

BEIJING

MATERIALS LEVERAGE

The WF6 squeeze is the rare-earth playbook one layer up the chain: not banning chips but denying the world the boring inputs that make them. Beijing has found a chokepoint that needs no navy — and one the West spent years not thinking to stockpile.⁴

IN BRIEF

H200 in limbo: licences approved, chips barely shipped — the export "win" that books almost no revenue as Beijing quietly steers buyers to domestic stacks.³

On deck: Kimi K3's full open weights land 27 July (p8), the next test of the commoditisation thesis.

SOURCES 1 Forbes, "Apple briefly passes Nvidia as most valuable company," 17 Jul 2026; CompaniesMarketCap. 2 SiliconANGLE, 21 Jul 2026; Nvidia Newsroom. 3 CNBC; Bloomberg (Commerce testimony), 14 Jul 2026. 4 BigGo Finance; Astute Group; China Briefing, Jul 2026 (WF6 price via trade aggregators — indicative, not primary). 5 MarkTechPost, 19 Jul 2026; interconnects.ai; TechNode, Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY • THE HOME LAB

The Memory Squeeze Reaches the Shelf

The contract-price story from No. 48 has become a retail one: GPUs for local-LLM builders are climbing on the same DRAM shortage — while Ollama quietly turns its bare command into an agent.

The memory crunch this desk has tracked in the contract market is now visible at the checkout. Samsung is seeking DRAM and LPDDR price rises north of 20% for the third quarter, SK Hynix has reportedly scrapped the price caps in its long-term contracts, and TrendForce expects actual Q3 contract prices to land 13–18% higher quarter-on-quarter — the tightness Micron's chief warned would run "beyond 2027," now feeding straight through to the parts a home-lab build depends on.¹

For the reader assembling a rig, it lands on the GPU shelf. The GDDR7 shortage has pushed RTX 5090 street prices from roughly \$4,000 in June toward \$4,300–\$5,000-plus by mid-July, against a \$1,999 sticker that has been fiction for months; the 5080 sits around \$1,250–\$1,600.² The pragmatic counter-move the community keeps landing on is unchanged — a secondhand RTX 3090 for its 24GB of VRAM — with one fresh wrinkle: AMD's GDDR6-based RX 9070 XT has largely dodged the spike, making it a real value option for inference where CUDA is not mandatory.³

\$4,300+

MID-JULY STREET PRICE FOR AN RTX 5090 (MSRP \$1,999)
AS THE GDDR7 SHORTAGE BITES — GPU AGGREGATOR
FIGURES, INDICATIVE RATHER THAN AUTHORITATIVE.

The software side quietly changed shape. Ollama's v0.32 line, released on 16 July, redefines what the bare ollama command does: type it with no arguments and you now land in an interactive agent — chat, code, web search and task delegation — rather than a plain model runner, alongside better Gemma 4 tool-calling and a fixed MLX cache leak.⁴ It is a small change with a large implication

GPU	MSRP	MID-JUL STREET	HOME-LAB READ
RTX 5090 (32GB)	\$1,999	\$4,300–5,000+	halo card, priced out
RTX 3090 (24GB, used)	—	~\$900–1,100	still the value king
RX 9070 XT (16GB)	\$599	near MSRP	dodged the spike

for the self-hoster: the local stack is drifting from "run a model" toward "run an assistant," on hardware the same reader is now paying a premium to own.

THE SCEPTIC

Two cautions worth keeping. The RTX 5090 street prices and the "which model fits 24GB" benchmarks that circulate come from GPU and LLM blogs, not primary sources — directionally right, precisely wrong. And an Ollama that boots into an agent is convenient until it isn't: an interactive default that can call tools and search the web is a bigger attack surface than a model runner, and worth pinning to a version you have read the notes for before it updates itself under you.

The models the rig has to run keep getting heavier at the top and lighter in the middle. Kimi K3's full open weights arrive on 27 July and Qwen3.8-Max's release is promised behind it — neither fits a 24GB card at full precision, but the quantised mid-size models the community actually deploys keep improving, and the pragmatic target for a single 3090 remains a strong ~27–32B model at 4-bit rather than a frontier giant.⁵ The home lab's supply of "runs-on-your-own-metal" capability keeps refilling even as the metal gets dearer — the squeeze is on the hardware, not the software.

IN BRIEF

The AMD case: where CUDA isn't mandatory, an RX 9070 XT on GDDR6 sidesteps the GDDR7 premium entirely — the value build of the moment.³

Pin your versions: an agentic Ollama that self-updates is a moving attack surface; pin what you've read the notes for.

DRAM +20%

3090 STILL KING

OLLAMA AGENT

THE SQUEEZE, IN ONE LINE

Contract DRAM up 13–18% quarter-on-quarter, Samsung seeking 20%-plus, SK Hynix scrapping its caps — the shortage Micron's chief says runs "beyond 2027" is now the single biggest input cost between a home-lab plan and a working rig.¹ The counsel is unchanged: buy the VRAM you need now, not the halo card you want.

SOURCES 1 TrendForce, 3 Jul 2026; BigGo Finance; Notebookcheck, Jul 2026. 2 Local AI Master / Compute Market street-price trackers, mid-Jul 2026 (aggregator figures — indicative). 3 GPU community pricing roundups, Jul 2026. 4 Ollama release notes v0.32.0–v0.32.1, 11–16 Jul 2026. 5 interconnects.ai; Ollama model library, Jul 2026 (quantised-model guidance — indicative).

THE KIT

Unpacked Comes to London: A Wider Fold, and Glasses With No Screen

Samsung held its first London Unpacked in fourteen years on 22 July, unveiling a reshaped foldable line, its first commercial AI glasses — and a set of prices that keep climbing.

Samsung brought Galaxy Unpacked back to London on 22 July for the first time since the Galaxy S3 era, and used it to reshape the foldable rather than merely iterate it. The headline hardware is a new "Flex Titanium" display architecture — a titanium-alloy film beneath the OLED, plus a titanium support plate — meant to flatten the crease that has defined the category, debuting across a Galaxy Z Fold 8 line that now splits into a wider, passport-format "Fold 8" and a taller "Fold 8 Ultra," both on the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5.¹

The more interesting object is the one without a screen. Samsung's first commercial AI glasses — Galaxy Glasses, codenamed Jinju — are audio-first and display-free, running Android XR with Gemini, carrying a 12-megapixel camera and offloading the heavy processing to a paired phone, and pairing with both Android and iOS.² That confirms the screenless, audio-led leak this desk carried in No. 46, and sets up a sharp contrast with the Xreal ROG R1 (No. 47–48, reviewed-but-overpriced at \$849.99): Samsung's glasses are reported to start far lower, with a micro-LED display model held back for a rumoured 2027.

\$379–499

REPORTED STARTING PRICE FOR SAMSUNG'S SCREENLESS GALAXY GLASSES (SHIPS THIS AUTUMN) — LEAKED AHEAD OF THE KEYNOTE AND AWAITING FULL CONFIRMATION, BUT WELL UNDER THE XREAL R1'S \$849.99.

The catch, as ever, is the bill. Pricing across the line was still leak-based at press time — the keynote closed at

9pm Singapore time on the day of this edition — but the reported figures point up: a Fold 8 holding near \$1,999, the Fold 8 Ultra pushing past \$2,100 (about €2,199 for 256GB in Europe), and a Flip 8 climbing toward \$1,099–\$1,200.³ A refreshed Galaxy Watch 9 and Watch Ultra 2 round out the launch. We are holding the exact numbers as reported, not confirmed, until Samsung's own store pages settle.

The wrist got a quieter refresh. A Galaxy Watch 9 and a Watch Ultra 2 — the latter tipped to carry a new Snapdragon Wear Elite chip — headline the wearable side, with a second-generation Galaxy Ring rumoured but, unlike the glasses, not clearly confirmed at the keynote.⁴ For the reader already wearing an Oura and a Whoop (p18), none of it forces a change; the more interesting wrist question this year is not which watch but which recovery number to trust, and Samsung's health story has not moved far enough to answer it.

THE CHATTER

The pre-event forums split predictably: enthusiasm for a genuinely thinner, flatter Fold and for the first Samsung glasses cheap enough to consider, set against fatigue at a foldable now flirting with \$2,100 in a year when memory costs alone (p8) explain part of the climb. The audio-first glasses drew the most goodwill — a bet, echoed across the coverage, that the right first move in face-worn computing is one you are not embarrassed to wear.

FLEX TITANIUM

GALAXY GLASSES

PRICE CREEP

THE SCEPTIC

Two years of "the crease is fixed" have taught foldable buyers to wait for the reviews, and Flex Titanium is a claim until a teardown confirms it. The bigger tell is the price: at \$2,100 the Fold 8 Ultra is no longer an early-adopter's toy but a considered purchase against a flagship slab that costs half as much and folds not at all. The glasses are the more honest bet — cheap enough that being wrong is affordable.

AGAINST THE FIELD

Xreal ROG R1 (No. 47–48): \$849.99, display-equipped, reviewed as overpriced. **Galaxy Glasses:** reported \$379–499, screenless, Gemini-driven. Samsung's bet is that most people want a camera and an assistant on their face before they want a screen on it — and has priced accordingly.

SOURCES 1 Samsung Global Newsroom (event); SamMobile; PhoneArena pre-event roundups, 16–22 Jul 2026. 2 AndroidHeadlines; TechTimes, 16 Jul 2026 (Galaxy Glasses / Jinju). 3 Android Authority; PhoneArena price leaks, Jul 2026 — leaked figures, not Samsung-confirmed at press time. Xreal ROG R1 pricing: TechRadar, No. 47–48 continuity. 4 SamMobile; Android Central pre-event roundups, Jul 2026 (Watch 9 / Ultra 2 — reported).

THE CONNECTED HOME

The Spec Runs Ahead Again

Home Assistant's July release finally rebuilt its Matter server just as Matter itself jumped to 1.6 — NFC-tap setup, cross-ecosystem sharing, smarter thermostats. The migrator's takeaway: adopt slowly.

The pattern that defines this desk repeated itself in July: the platform caught up to a spec that promptly moved. Home Assistant 2026.7, stable since 1 July, rebuilt its Matter server from the ground up — off the old Python-and-C++ stack onto a TypeScript implementation (matter.js), certified against Matter 1.5.1 — and added optional diagnostic sensors that expose a device's Thread channel, routing role and network name, the kind of visibility a self-hoster has wanted for two years.¹ Purpose-built automation triggers, previewed in No. 47, also graduated from Labs to the default for everyone.

Then the standard jumped. The Connectivity Standards Alliance released Matter 1.6 on 17 June, adding NFC-tap commissioning (tap a phone to a device to set it up), cross-ecosystem device sharing so one gadget can live in Apple Home and Google Home at once, and a smarter thermostat cluster; early 1.6 hardware is already appearing on show floors.² Thread, notably, has not moved in step — the network layer underneath all of this is still on 1.4, with vendors shifting to Thread-first portfolios rather than chasing a new revision.³

1.6

THE MATTER VERSION AS OF MID-JULY — ONE AHEAD OF THE 1.5.1 THAT HOME ASSISTANT'S REBUILT SERVER WAS JUST CERTIFIED AGAINST. THE GAP BETWEEN SPEC AND SUPPORT IS THE DESK'S STANDING WEATHER.

For the reader mid-migration from Lutron, the practical news is that there is no urgent news, which is itself the counsel. Home Assistant's `lutron_caseta` integration still

THE MIGRATOR'S STANDING RULE

Keep the lighting you trust on the bridge you trust (Caséta / RA2 / RadioRA 3 / Homeworks QSX via `lutron_caseta`); add Matter devices one at a time; let a new spec version reach hardware before you chase it. The reliability of a lighting system is worth more than a version number, and nothing in the July releases changes that calculus.⁴

covers Caséta, RA2 Select, RadioRA 3 and Homeworks QSX through the Smart Bridge, with no July change to force a decision.⁴ The winning posture across the migrator threads is the same one the spec churn keeps rewarding: let 1.6 hardware settle, keep the lighting you trust on its own reliable bridge, and add Matter devices one at a time rather than rebuilding the house around a version number.

The cross-ecosystem sharing in 1.6 is the feature worth caring about, because it attacks the migrator's actual pain. Until now a Matter device joined one controller and grudgingly bridged to others; 1.6 lets a single gadget be natively shared into Apple Home and Google Home at once, which is exactly the messy multi-hub reality a Lutron-plus-Home-Assistant household lives in.² The catch is the usual one — the feature exists in the spec before it exists in your devices, and a controller certified to 1.5.1 will not conjure 1.6 behaviour from firmware that predates it.

IN BRIEF

New kit: ZemiSmart's Matter IR Blaster and AC Controller (3 Jul) pulls legacy infrared appliances into Apple Home, Google Home and Alexa — a cheap way to Matter-ify the one air-conditioner that will never speak Thread.⁵

No delta: Apple Home's iOS 27 rebuild (No. 46) still targets a September ship; nothing new surfaced this window.

MATTER 1.6

MATTER.JS

ADOPT SLOWLY

THREAD WATCH

The quiet story is what did not move: Thread stays on 1.4 while Matter races to 1.6. The application layer keeps adding features the network layer underneath already supports fine — which is reassuring for anyone who has built out a Thread border-router mesh and would rather not rebuild it. Buy Thread-1.4 kit without fear of imminent obsolescence.³

SOURCES 1 [home-assistant.io changelog](https://home-assistant.io/changelog/) & blog, 1 Jul 2026; Matter Alpha. 2 MacRumors, 17 Jun 2026; matter-smarthome.de (Matter 1.6). 3 Thread Group status, mid-2026. 4 Home Assistant `lutron_caseta` integration docs, 2026. 5 TechTimes, 3 Jul 2026.

THE GOOD LIFE

A Flagship Season for the Ear

From a \$399 headphone to a \$210,000 speaker, the summer's audio launches span the whole ladder at once — while the auction market that sets watch prices just posted its strongest half in years.

If there is a theme to the season's audio, it is range. At the summit, Focal unveiled the Diva Alta Utopia — a wireless all-in-one built on its Diva powered-speaker platform and priced, without apology, at US\$210,000 a pair — while Bowers & Wilkins showed the fifth generation of its 800 Series Diamond, seven models deep, with orders opening on 9 September.¹ These are objects of contemplation more than purchase, but they set the ceiling the rest of the market is measured against.

The more useful news sits far lower on the ladder. Sennheiser's new flagship wireless headphone, the Momentum 5, arrives at US\$399 with 42mm transducers, aptX Lossless, head-tracked spatial audio, a user-replaceable battery and a rated 57 hours — genuinely long-haul figures for a Tokyo flight — even as its parent shops the headphone division around.² Below that again, iFi previewed the iDSD GR2 portable DAC as the ground-up heir to its five-star Gryphon, and Topping's DX1 II desktop DAC/amp landed at US\$119 — a reminder that the price of very good has kept falling while the price of the very best has not.³

+70%

H1 2026 COMBINED CHRISTIE'S / SOTHEBY'S / PHILLIPS AUCTION SALES, YEAR-ON-YEAR, TO ABOUT US\$6.8BN INCLUDING FEES — WITH LUXURY COLLECTIBLES, WATCHES AMONG THEM, UP 25%.

On the watch side the news this fortnight is the market, not a novelty. The major spring references from Rolex, Patek and AP are already known; what moved is the

money behind them, with the big three houses reporting a first half up about 70% year-on-year to US\$6.8 billion, luxury collectibles up a quarter.⁴ Against that backdrop the mid-July Sotheby's watch sales in Singapore and Tokyo are the results worth waiting for — and, honestly, still worth waiting for: published top-lot figures had not surfaced by press time, so this desk holds them rather than guess.⁵

The escape half of the desk points, as it often does, at Tokyo. A new apartment-style property, the Oshiage Koko Hotel Residences, opened on 16 July with 25 units from about 42 square metres, full kitchens, and a rooftop framing the Skytree — a base for the reader who travels with an eleven-year-old and prefers a residence to a room.⁶ Set against the firm-SGD, soft-yen arithmetic on p15 and p20, the object worth buying this season may not be the \$210,000 speaker at all, but the airfare that gets you to the shops selling its smaller cousins.

THE CHATTER

The audiophile forums are fixed less on the \$210,000 Focal than on the Sennheiser-for-sale line: a flagship headphone launching the same season its maker's headphone arm is on the block reads, to the sceptics, as a division being dressed for a buyer. The counter-view is that the Momentum 5 is simply the best all-rounder Sennheiser has shipped in years, and that who owns the factory matters less to the listener than the 57-hour battery does.

AUDIO

AUCTIONS +70%

SOTHEBY'S PENDING

THE LADDER, IN ONE GLANCE

\$119 Topping DX1 II desktop DAC/amp — the sane entry.
\$399 Sennheiser Momentum 5, 57-hour ANC flagship — the one to actually buy. **~\$1,000s** iFi iDSD GR2 portable, previewed. **\$210,000** Focal Diva Alta Utopia — the ceiling. Rarely has a single season laid the whole ladder out so plainly.³

THE WATCH READ

With the spring novelties long known and this fortnight's Sotheby's Singapore and Tokyo results still unpublished, the honest watch story is the money, not the metal: a first half up ~70% to US\$6.8bn says the collectible bid is back, but a strong auction market and a strong specific result are not the same thing — this desk holds the latter until it prints.^{4,5}

SOURCES 1 What Hi-Fi?, Jul 2026 (Focal Diva Alta Utopia; B&W 800 D5, orders 9 Sep). 2 What Hi-Fi?, 2026 (Sennheiser Momentum 5; division reported for sale). 3 TrustedReviews / What Hi-Fi? (iFi iDSD GR2); Forbes, 30 Jun 2026 (Topping DX1 II). 4 The Art Newspaper, 15 Jul 2026 (H1 2026 auction totals). 5 Sotheby's watch sales, Singapore & Tokyo, 15–17 Jul 2026 — results unpublished at press time; no figure printed. 6 en.itravelblog.net, 2026 (Oshiage Koko Hotel Residences, opened 16 Jul).

SCREEN & SOUND

Half a Billion Views for a Film Ten Months Away

The first *Avengers: Doomsday* trailer set a record the week before Comic-Con — where Marvel returns to Hall H and Apple TV+ arrives for the first time.

The biggest thing on screens this week was an advertisement for something that does not exist yet. The first full trailer for *Avengers: Doomsday* dropped on 20 July and drew 503 million views in twenty-four hours — the largest trailer debut ever for a Disney film, past *Deadpool & Wolverine*, and the second-largest of all time behind only *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* — crossing 300 million in its first eight hours and dragging \$16.5 million of tied-in presales on day one, for a film that does not open until 2027.¹ It is the anticipation economy in one number, and the Long Read (p21) takes it from there.

The timing is not accidental: San Diego Comic-Con runs 23–26 July, and both the trailer and the calendar point at Hall H. Marvel Studios returns to the room on Saturday 25 July for the first time in two years, Kevin Feige and the Russo brothers expected alongside the *Doomsday* cast; the same afternoon, Apple TV+ makes its first-ever Hall H appearance, fronting *Silo*, *Dark Matter*, the 19-E Emmy-nominated *Widow's Bay* and a slate that includes *Blade Runner 2099*.² A streamer with no franchise behind it, taking the biggest stage in fandom, is its own small sign of where the leverage now sits.

503M

VIEWS OF THE *AVENGERS: DOOMSDAY* TRAILER IN 24 HOURS — A DISNEY RECORD AND THE SECOND-BIGGEST TRAILER DEBUT EVER, FOR A FILM THAT OPENS IN 2027.

There are things you can actually watch, too. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* — billed as the first

feature shot entirely in IMAX 70mm — led the box office on its 17–19 July opening, and *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* arrives on 31 July to test whether the trailer that beat *Doomsday*'s can convert to seats.³ On the audio side the marquee release is the Rolling Stones' *Foreign Tongues*, reportedly their first album since 2023 and said to feature a final, pre-death Charlie Watts session, with new records from Motionless in White and others filling out the month.⁴

The *Foreign Tongues* guest list is the story on the music side — Paul McCartney, Steve Winwood and The Cure's Robert Smith are all reported to appear, alongside that final Watts session — but the street date has moved around enough in coverage that this desk treats it as reported, not fixed.⁴ Around it the month is busy rather than era-defining: Motionless in White's *Decades* landed on 17 July, and records from the pop A-list are stacked into the last week. As ever, the album that will actually matter is rarely the one with the biggest pre-release noise — the anticipation trap, in miniature.

THE CHATTER

The fan reaction to a record-breaking trailer for a 2027 film is doing the studios' work for them, and the sceptics in the threads know it: a view is not a ticket, and the last cycle's biggest trailers did not all become the biggest films. The counter, which Disney is banking, is that half a billion views is a marketing asset in itself — the anticipation is the product until the film is.

TRAILER RECORD

HALL H

THE ODYSSEY

THE RELEASE CALENDAR

Now: *The Odyssey* (Nolan, IMAX 70mm) leading the box office. **31 Jul:** *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* — the one film whose trailer out-viewed *Doomsday*'s, now the conversion test. **2027:** *Avengers: Doomsday*, already 503M views deep. The gap between the last two is the whole point of p21.

HALL H NOTE

Apple TV+ taking a first-ever Hall H slot — fronting *Silo*, *Dark Matter*, *Blade Runner 2099* and the 19-E Emmy-nominated *Widow's Bay* — is a streamer buying fandom's biggest stage without a comic-book library to stand on. For the sci-fi reader it is the more interesting booking of the weekend: prestige television now competes for the room the tentpoles built.²

SOURCES 1 Variety, 20 Jul 2026; ComicBook.com; ABC News (trailer views, presales). 2 TechTimes, 20 Jul 2026; Deadline; Marvel.com (SDCC / Hall H schedule). 3 Boxoffice Pro, 19 Jul 2026 (*The Odyssey*); Marvel.com (*Brand New Day*, 31 Jul). 4 Official Charts; Ultimate Classic Rock, 2026 — *Foreign Tongues* guests and street date reported, not independently confirmed.

THE FAMILY DESK

The Paediatricians Drop the Clock

New guidance retires the decade-old "hours per day" rule for screens in favour of content, context and the individual child — a quieter, harder message than a number. General guidance, not medical advice.

For a decade the advice to parents came with a number attached: so many hours of screen time a day, and no more. That framework is being retired. Coverage published on 20 July lays out how paediatric guidance has shifted away from hourly limits toward what a child is actually doing on a screen, in what context, and how it fits the rest of their life — a recognition that an hour of video-calling a grandparent and an hour of doom-scrolling are not the same hour.¹ For the parent of an eleven-year-old, it is at once more honest and more demanding: there is no longer a clean line to enforce, only a set of judgements to keep making.

The policy world, meanwhile, is still reaching for the clean line. More than thirty U.S. states have now passed laws restricting or banning phones in K-12 classrooms, and the underlying research on youth mental health keeps complicating the picture rather than settling it: a study of more than 50,000 U.S. children and adolescents found screen time associated with anxiety and depression, but with physical activity, sleep duration and bedtime regularity acting as parallel drivers — screens as one thread in a knot, not the knot.² A separate meta-analysis found regular exercise measurably improved children's sleep quality and duration.³

30+

U.S. STATES THAT HAVE NOW RESTRICTED OR BANNED CELLPHONES IN K-12 CLASSROOMS — POLICY REACHING FOR A BRIGHT LINE JUST AS CLINICAL GUIDANCE ABANDONS ONE.

THE THREE LEVERS

Sleep: ~half of children fall short of the recommended hours — the highest-evidence, lowest-glamour fix.⁴

Movement: a 2026 meta-analysis found exercise measurably improved children's sleep quality and duration.³ **Purpose:** a video-call with a grandparent and an hour of doom-scrolling are not the same hour — curate the use, not just the clock.

The takeaway for a household is neither panic nor permissiveness. The move-more, sleep-more, screens-in-their-place message that Scottish and other 2026 reviews keep landing on is dull precisely because it works: the levers with the best evidence behind them — sleep, movement, and what the screen is being used for — are the ones a parent can actually pull, and none of them requires a stopwatch.⁴

What replaces the clock is harder to police but easier to defend. The three levers with the strongest evidence — enough sleep, enough movement, and attention to what the screen is for — are all things a parent of an eleven-year-old can shape directly, and none of them turns bedtime into a stopwatch argument. The shift is really from prohibition to curation: less "how long" and more "doing what, and instead of what." It asks more of the parent and delivers a steadier household in return.¹

DON'T BE ALARMIST

Worth saying plainly, because the guidance itself now says it: the popular story blaming screens and smartphones for an adolescent mental-health crisis runs well ahead of the current evidence. Effects track content, context and the individual child, not raw hours — and the same week's news that 85% of Australian under-16s kept using social media despite a national ban (p14) is a caution that blunt, number-based fixes tend to underdeliver. Treat this as information, not medical advice.

SCREEN GUIDANCE

SLEEP & MOVEMENT

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE KNOT, NOT THE THREAD

The 50,000-child study is the useful corrective: screen time did track with anxiety and depression, but so did sleep, activity and bedtime regularity, all pulling in parallel.² Screens are one thread in a knot, not the knot — which is why pulling only that thread rarely loosens anything, and why the honest advice is dull, plural and un-viral.

SOURCES 1 The Conversation / Medical Xpress, "Screen-time guidelines have shifted," 20 Jul 2026. 2 *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* (Nature), 2026 (50,000+ children); The Conversation, 20 Jul 2026 (state phone laws). 3 *European Child & Adolescent Psychiatry*, Feb 2026 (exercise/sleep meta-analysis). 4 University of Strathclyde / Active Healthy Kids Scotland, 2026. General guidance, not medical advice.

A BAN THAT 85% OF KIDS IGNORED

Australia's world-first under-16 social-media ban is running into the gap between a law and a login. Testers who advised the government opened fifty fresh accounts across nine platforms, declared themselves sixteen each time, and were asked to prove it exactly once — only Kick refused them.¹ A BMJ analysis reported that more than 85% of Australian under-16s were still using social media three months after the ban took effect, with about two-thirds encountering an age check that was usually self-declaration or a selfie.² Canberra has doubled the maximum corporate penalty to A\$49.5 million and accused platforms of engineering the ban to fail; the platforms say verification at that scale is genuinely hard.³ The lesson for a parent watching from Singapore is not that rules are useless, but that a rule a child can wave away with a birthdate is not the thing keeping them safe.

WASHINGTON'S VERSION LOSES ITS TEETH

The U.S. attempt took a different route to a similar place. The House passed a bipartisan KIDS Act consolidating some fourteen child-safety proposals — but stripped out the "duty of care" that was the heart of the Kids Online Safety Act, prompting Senator Blumenthal to call the House version "dead in the Senate."⁴ What survives leans on age verification, the same mechanism Australia has just shown can be defeated by a confident eleven-year-old and a selfie.

THE HOMEWORK MACHINE, MEASURED

On AI the useful finding this month is about learning, not safety. Pew reports 54% of U.S. teens now use AI chatbots for schoolwork, and one in ten for "all or most" of it; a separate study found that students handed a chatbot that gave direct answers did worse on later

exams than peers who used no AI at all, while those given a bot that offered only hints matched the no-AI group.⁵ The parenting translation is precise: the tool that does the thinking is the one that hurts; the tool that prompts the thinking does not. It is a rule an eleven-year-old can be taught — "ask it for a hint, not the answer" — and one worth teaching before the habit sets the other way.

A NOTE ON VERIFICATION ITSELF

The deeper problem the week exposes is that age verification, the mechanism both Canberra and Washington are leaning on, sits in an awkward middle: strong enough to demand a face scan or an ID, weak enough that a confident child defeats it, and intrusive enough that adults resist it. Australia's own testers were asked to prove their age exactly once across fifty attempts.¹ For a Singapore household the practical posture is neither to trust the platforms' gates nor to build a surveillance state at home, but to do the unglamorous thing — talk about what the child actually does online, and keep the devices out of the bedroom at night, where the evidence is clearest.

A rule a child can wave away with a birthdate is not the thing keeping them safe.

IN BRIEF

Sleep first: Scottish 2026 data found roughly half of children fall short of recommended sleep — the lever with the least glamour and the most evidence.⁶

Continuity: the Roblox child-safety settlement math (No. 48) is unchanged this week; no new state has joined since.

TWO BANS, ONE LESSON

Australia: under-16 ban, 85%+ still using, penalty doubled to A\$49.5m — enforcement is the hard part, not the law.^{2,3}

United States: KIDS Act passes the House but strips KOSA's duty of care; "dead in the Senate."⁴ Both now lean on age verification; Australia has just shown how leaky that is.

THE SCEPTIC

It is tempting to read two stumbling bans as proof that nothing works, and that is the wrong lesson. The point is narrower: *blunt, number-based prohibitions* underdeliver, while the dull household levers — sleep, movement, curated use, conversation — keep showing up in the evidence. The regulator reaches for the bright line because it is legible; the parent's better tools are the ones that don't make headlines. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 NBC News / The Next Web, ~7 Jul 2026 (age-check testing). 2 *The BMJ*, via NBC News, Jul 2026 (85% figure; primary paper not independently reviewed). 3 JURIST, Jun 2026 (A\$49.5m penalty). 4 The Hill; Public Knowledge; EFF, Jun 2026 (KIDS Act / KOSA). 5 Pew Research, 2026 (teen AI use); K-12 Dive, 2026 (chatbot-and-exams study). 6 University of Strathclyde, 2026. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK

An oil bid, a coin-flip Fed, and gold at a record

A widening Gulf war keeps a bid under crude just as a hawkish chair drags July's meeting toward a live call; gold prints a record while bitcoin only nudges a five-week high. Market explanation and education, not investment advice — forecasts are flagged as forecasts throughout.

VWRA	GLOBAL BONDS (BNDW)	US 10Y	DX	USD/SGD	BRENT	GOLD	BTC
\$186.98 ▼	4.25% yield	4.60% ▲	100.59 ▼	1.2912	\$91.10 ▲	\$4,098 ▲	~\$66,300 ▲

Start with the barrel, because everything else this week bends around it. The Houthis blockade of Saudi Arabia and Iran's tanker strike inside Hormuz (p3) kept a war premium bid under crude: Brent settled around \$91.10 on 21 July, up about 2% on the day and roughly a fifth above where the month began.¹ An oil bid is also an inflation bid, and it is landing on a Federal Reserve chair who has spent a month telling anyone listening that inflation is still "too high."

That is the pivot. Chair Kevin Warsh's June debut moved the dot plot from zero hike-forecasters to nine, and his July testimony hardened the message; the market has repriced the 28-29 July meeting from a near-certain hold toward something closer to a coin flip. The exact probability is genuinely unsettled — aggregators this week spanned roughly the high-teens to near-50% for a 25bp hike — so the honest statement is that the odds have risen sharply and materially, not that they sit at a single clean number.² Treat any point estimate, including that one, as a forecast.

An oil bid is also an inflation bid — and it is landing on a chair who keeps saying inflation is too high.

The mechanical chain shows up across the board. The 10-year yield sits at 4.60%, yet the dollar has eased rather than firmed — DXY around 100.6, off its late-June peak — as a war premium and a divided-Fed debate pull the currency two ways at once.³ USD/JPY holds near 162.5, close to multi-decade lows, a hawkish Fed still out-hawking a hawkish Bank of Japan; USD/SGD is little changed around 1.29, so the firm-SGD travel arithmetic

on p20 points the same way it did.⁴ The fresh 50% U.S. tariff on Canada (p4) adds another upside-inflation pebble to the same scale.

VWRA — last verified at \$186.98 on 19 July, and held there rather than guessed at a fresher figure — is being dragged less by the war than by chips: the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index fell into a bear market on 17 July, down more than 20% from its 22 June peak, after Kimi K3 revived the fear that "more compute" is a commoditising trade (p7).⁵ **Global bonds** are behaving like ballast again — BNDW yields about 4.25%, AGGU's underlying yield near 3.97% — offering real diversification as yields stay high but do not spike.⁶

Gold is the standout. It printed around \$4,098/oz this week, at or near a record, and central banks keep buying into it regardless of price — the war-hedge and real-asset bids reinforcing rather than fighting the dollar this time.⁷ **Bitcoin** managed only a five-week high near \$66,300, behaving as the highest-beta risk asset of the four rather than a hedge — a liquidity read, not a haven one.⁸

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Still a higher-for-longer regime, now with an oil shock that is also an inflation shock and a live-again July Fed. VWRA's softness reads as a semiconductor story more than a rates verdict; global bonds are earning their keep as ballast; gold's hedge and the dollar are, unusually, pulling the same way, which is why it can rip while bitcoin only nudges. Bitcoin remains the most liquidity-sensitive of the four. None of this is a recommendation to buy, sell or hold any of them — the reader's anchors remain VWRA and global bonds; gold and BTC are read here for sensitivity, not endorsed.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

JULY LIVE

GOLD RECORD

SOURCES 1 TradingEconomics; Fortune, 21 Jul 2026 (Brent). 2 Bloomberg, 14 Jul 2026 (Warsh testimony); CME FedWatch / Kalshi / Polymarket, Jul 2026 — hike-odds range, unsettled. 3 TradingEconomics; Vantage Markets note, 20 Jul 2026 (10Y, DXY). 4 TradingEconomics / MTFX, 20 Jul 2026 (USD/JPY); exchangerates.org.uk, 21 Jul 2026 (USD/SGD). 5 StockAnalysis.com / Investing.com, 19 Jul 2026 (VWRA); Bloomberg, 17 Jul 2026 (SOX). 6 stockanalysis.com (BNDW); iShares (AGGU), 20 Jul 2026. 7 CNBC Select / JM Bullion, 21 Jul 2026 (gold). 8 Fortune; Sunday Guardian, 21 Jul 2026 (BTC). Market explanation, not investment advice.

CURIOSITIES

The Third Visitor From Another Star

An interstellar comet is crossing our sky this week, the gravitational-wave catalogue just passed 390, and NTU found exotic light hiding in a 200-year-old shadow.

Somewhere over the constellation Gemini this week, a piece of another solar system is passing through ours. Comet 3I/ATLAS — only the third confirmed interstellar object ever detected, after 'Oumuamua and Borisov — was crossing Gemini as of 20 July on its way through the inner solar system, having been picked up by NASA's ATLAS survey in Chile.¹ It poses no threat: its closest approach to Earth is a comfortable 269 million kilometres, a flyby of a visitor that will never come back, the kind of once-in-a-lifetime object that older skywatchers would have read as an omen and modern ones read as data — a distinction the Long Read (p21) has some fun with.

The instruments that catch the rare are getting better at making it routine. A new release of the gravitational-wave catalogue added 161 fresh black-hole collisions in a single batch, pushing the total tally of detections to 390 — and buried in the data, an anomalous signal has revived hopes of finally spotting a theorised primordial black hole.² Astronomers separately reported 31 of the oldest quasars ever seen, including the two earliest on record, blazing when the universe was just 670 million years old.³

390

TOTAL GRAVITATIONAL-WAVE DETECTIONS AFTER THE LATEST CATALOGUE ADDED 161 BLACK-HOLE MERGERS AT ONCE — THE EXTRAORDINARY BECOMING A CENSUS.

Closer to home, the strangeness was hiding in plain sight. Physicists at Nanyang Technological University found a "surprisingly simple" way to generate optical

skyrmions — exotic, knotted structures of light — using the Poisson spot, the bright point that appears at the centre of a circular object's shadow and that has been an optical curiosity for two hundred years.⁴ And in the merely delightful column: NASA's Perseverance rover has now driven a full marathon on Mars, 26.2 miles of total odometer, and biologists described singing mice that inflate a throat air sac to hit their highest notes — an apparent trick unknown in any other animal.⁵

The most sci-fi item of the fortnight was a piece of theory made briefly real. Physicists reported simulating the Penrose process — the extraction of energy from a spinning black hole, a mainstay of the genre since the 1970s — using a stationary laboratory device that generates a synthetic ultrafast rotation, letting them study on a bench a phenomenon that otherwise exists only at the edge of a collapsed star.⁶ It is the recurring pleasure of this desk: the exotic turning out to have a tabletop analogue, whether it is knotted light hiding in a two-century-old shadow or the physics of a black hole recreated without one.

THE CHATTER

3I/ATLAS is, predictably, catnip for the it's-a-spaceship crowd, and the astronomers are patient about it: an interstellar comet is extraordinary enough without alien engineering, and its behaviour — a coma, a tail, a Sun-bound trajectory — is exactly what a very old, very fast dirty snowball from elsewhere should do. The wonder is that we can now catch a third of them at all.

3I/ATLAS

390 WAVES

NTU OPTICS

THE FAR EDGES, IN BRIEF

Mars: Perseverance has driven a full marathon — 26.2 miles of total odometer — on another planet.⁵ **Biology:** singing mice inflate a throat air sac to reach their highest notes, a trick apparently unknown in any other animal.⁵ **Home turf:** the NTU optics work came out of a 200-year-old curiosity, the bright Poisson spot at the centre of a round shadow.⁴

WHY IT MATTERS

A catalogue that jumps by 161 detections at once (p16 lead) marks a threshold: gravitational-wave astronomy has gone from hunting single events to compiling a census, the point at which a new sense stops being a miracle and becomes an instrument. The buried anomaly hinting at a primordial black hole is the reminder that even a census still turns up the genuinely strange.²

SOURCES 1 Space.com; NASA Science; PBS NewsHour, Jul 2026 (3I/ATLAS, crossing Gemini 20 Jul). 2 ScienceDaily, Jul 2026 (gravitational-wave catalogue, 390 detections). 3 ScienceDaily, Jul 2026 (31 oldest quasars). 4 ScienceDaily, 13 Jul 2026 (NTU optical skyrmions / Poisson spot). 5 ScienceDaily, Jul 2026 (Perseverance marathon); Science News, Jul 2026 (singing mice). 6 ScienceDaily, 12 Jul 2026 (Penrose-process laboratory simulation).

LOVE & LIFE

Feeling Loved Beats Being Loving

A new study separates two things we usually blur — and finds that the sense of being loved does more for a relationship than the act of loving. Meanwhile, three in four online daters say they would date a machine.

It sounds like a distinction without a difference until someone tests it. A July study in *Frontiers in Psychology* pulled apart "feeling loved" from "being loving" — the passive sense of being cherished versus the active work of cherishing — and, using an extreme-groups design comparing clinically distressed with highly satisfied people across five measures, found that feeling loved was the stronger predictor of relationship satisfaction.¹ The uncomfortable implication for anyone who prides themselves on effort: how much you love may matter less to the health of a relationship than whether your partner can feel it landing.

The market for connection, meanwhile, is quietly turning against the swipe. Activity-based and "experience-first" dating is surging as the big apps report slowing growth; Hinge has climbed to third in U.S. market share and first across the U.K. and the Nordics, its voice-note prompts credited for the lift, while Tinder's trend list for the year reads like a plea for sincerity — "clear-coding," being upfront about what you actually want.² The fatigue is real and measured: a longitudinal study found dating-app users accumulating emotional exhaustion over time, with loneliness and anxiety predicting the worst of it.³

77%

ONLINE DATERS WHO SAY THEY'D CONSIDER DATING AN AI, IN A NORTON SURVEY; 59% THINK IT POSSIBLE TO DEVELOP ROMANTIC FEELINGS FOR ONE. VENDOR-SPONSORED — READ WITH THAT IN MIND.

Which sets up the strangest data point of the month. A Norton survey found 77% of current online daters would

THE NUMBERS BEHIND THE MOOD

Under half of U.S. households are married couples; first-marriage age ~31/28.⁵ **~2.5 per 1,000:** the divorce rate, near a fifty-year low. **~24%:** adults worldwide feeling lonely, youngest cohorts highest.⁶ Fewer marrying; those who do, staying — and a young, lonelier cohort the machines are courting.

consider dating an AI, and 59% believe romantic feelings for one are possible — a figure worth holding at arm's length, given the company sells the security products such a world would need, but striking even discounted.⁴ Against all of it sits a curiously steadying statistic: the U.S. divorce rate has drifted to about 2.5 per thousand, near a fifty-year low, with younger cohorts divorcing less than their parents did at the same age.⁵ Fewer people are marrying; those who do are, so far, staying.

Underneath the app churn sits a slower demographic tide. Fewer than half of U.S. households are now married couples, the median age at first marriage has climbed to about 31 for men and 28 for women, and the birth rate keeps easing — a picture of people marrying later, less and more deliberately.⁵ The loneliness data rhymes with it: Gallup's global work has put the very-or-fairly-lonely share around a quarter of adults, highest among the young, and young men in the West among the loneliest of all — the cohort the AI-companion pitch is aimed squarely at.⁶

THE CHATTER

The "feeling loved beats being loving" finding is being read online as either liberating or damning, depending on the reader — permission to stop over-giving, or an indictment of the partner who gives in a language the other can't hear. The researchers' quieter point survives both readings: love has to be received to count, which is less a scoreboard than an instruction to find out how your particular person actually registers it.

BEING RECEIVED

ANTI-SWIPE

ARTIFICIAL INTIMACY

ON THE AI FIGURE

Hold Norton's 77% at arm's length: a security company sells the products a world of AI partners would need, and a survey it commissions has an interest in a startling number. Even discounted, though, the direction is real — the burnout research shows why a frictionless, always-affirming companion appeals to daters worn down by the swipe, and why "possible to feel something for one" is no longer a fringe answer.^{3,4}

SOURCES 1 *Frontiers in Psychology*, Jul 2026 ("feeling loved versus being loving"). 2 DatingNews.com / Business of Apps, 2026 (Hinge share); Tinder "Year in Swipe" via AOL, 2026. 3 Sharabi et al., *New Media & Society*, 2026 (dating-app burnout). 4 Norton "Artificial Intimacy" report, via Barchart, 2026 (vendor-sponsored survey). 5 US Census / roundups, 2025–26 (marriage, divorce, birth rate). 6 Gallup, 2023–25 (loneliness data — background, dates as noted).

FITNESS · THE LONG GAME

The Strength Dose That Comes With a Ceiling

A large study points to 90–120 minutes of strength training a week as the sweet spot — with no bonus above it — and a wearable head-to-head suggests which recovery number to trust. General guidance, not medical advice.

The most useful fitness finding of the season is also the most restraining. A Harvard-led study in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine* tracked strength training against mortality over decades and landed on a sweet spot of 90–120 minutes a week — with, crucially, no added benefit above 120 minutes.¹ That top band was associated with 19% and 27% lower risk of dying from cardiovascular and neurological disease respectively; even 15–30 minutes a week tracked to roughly a tenth lower cancer-death risk, and the biggest reduction of all — about 45% — came from combining strength work with aerobic exercise rather than doing either alone.² For a mid-40s reader, the message is oddly permissive: two focused sessions a week is not a compromise, it is the target.

It fits a run of research pointing the same way — that the capacity to exert force is a longevity signal in itself. A 2026 study of more than 5,400 women aged 63 and up found each seven-kilogram gain in grip strength linked to a 15% lower risk of death over eight years, extending the handshake-and-health thread from No. 48; the population is older and female, so the number travels as direction, not prescription, for a mixed mid-40s readership.³

THE DOSE, IN ONE GLANCE

90–120 min/week strength: the sweet spot, no bonus above it.¹ **+45%** lower death risk from combining strength with aerobic work vs either alone.² **Even 15–30 min/week** strength tracked ~10% lower cancer-death risk. The headline is permission, not pressure: two sessions is the target, not the compromise.

90–120

MINUTES OF WEEKLY STRENGTH TRAINING LINKED TO THE LARGEST MORTALITY BENEFIT — WITH NO FURTHER GAIN ABOVE TWO HOURS. TWO SESSIONS, NOT A SECOND JOB.

If you are going to let a wrist tell you how you slept, it helps to know which wrist to believe. A 2026 validation study put the consumer wearables head-to-head and found the Oura Gen 4 leading on heart-rate-variability accuracy — a concordance of 0.99 against reference — with Whoop moderate (0.94) and Garmin lower (0.87), and Oura also topping resting-heart-rate accuracy.⁴ The recovery score is only as good as the signal under it, and the signals are not equal.

DON'T OVERCLAIM (THE LONGEVITY BOX)

The counterweight to all of this is the at-home "biological age" test now booming in the wellness aisle. The considered view across recent coverage is blunt: epigenetic clocks are research tools, not consumer diagnostics; results vary widely between tests and are not reliable enough to steer individual decisions.⁵ When an influencer promises a doctor has "reversed biological age by 75%" ahead of some imminent announcement, the correct response is to name it as overclaiming, not to buy the kit. Whole-body age reversal is not available today; the honest wins remain the dull ones on this page. General guidance, not medical advice.

TWO SESSIONS

TRUST THE SIGNAL

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

WHICH NUMBER TO TRUST

If a wrist is going to grade your recovery, the 2026 validation head-to-head is the practical guide: Oura Gen 4 led on HRV accuracy (0.99 concordance), Whoop was moderate (0.94), Garmin lower (0.87), with Oura also topping resting heart rate.⁴ None is useless; they are just not interchangeable, and a recovery score is only as honest as the signal beneath it.

SOURCES ¹ *British Journal of Sports Medicine* (Harvard-led), 12 Jun 2026; Harvard Health, Jul 2026 coverage. ² ScienceDaily, Jun 2026 (mortality reductions). ³ ScienceDaily, May 2026 (grip strength, women 63+). ⁴ NCBI/PMC wearable-validation study, 2026 (Oura/Whoop/Garmin HRV). ⁵ The Conversation; Washington Post, 29 Apr 2026; Forbes, 23 Jun 2026 (biological-age tests). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE DIARY

The Autumn Squeeze

Three arena-sized names land within a month of each other this autumn — book the travel before the tickets.

SINGAPORE

DATED & BOOKABLE

29
AUG

★ Post Malone — Big Ass Stadium Tour, Singapore Indoor Stadium

WITH DON TOLIVER · ONE NIGHT ONLY · ON SALE VIA TICKETMASTER — HIS FIRST SG DATE SINCE 2023

25–
26
SEP

★ The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn, National Stadium

TWO NIGHTS, WITH CREEPY NUTS · STADIUM-SCALE PRODUCTION · THE MARQUEE SG CONCERT OF THE QUARTER

20
SEP

Belle & Sebastian — Esplanade Concert Hall

FROM S\$98 · A SEATED, HALL-SCALE NIGHT FOR THE READER WHO HAS AGED OUT OF THE PIT

After a quiet mid-year, the calendar bunches: a stadium pop bill, an arena rap night and a hall-sized indie show inside a month, all competing for the same September travel and hotel inventory. If a Weeknd weekend is the pick, book the room before the second night sells the first.¹

THE TABLE

SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

BLUE BOX CAFÉ BY TIFFANY & CO. — ION ORCHARD

Opened 15 July: Southeast Asia's first Tiffany café, on Level 3 of the ION flagship, with a menu by three-Michelin chef Julien Royer (Odette) — a Tiffany Burger, a chicken-rice riff, and a robin's-egg-blue room hung with Blue Boxes. The single most-hyped opening of the month; the honest caveat is Time Out's, that the mains "don't quite justify the price tag on flavour alone." Expect walk-in waits. Not halal.

Verdict: hype confirmed, value debated · **HYPED**

CAFÉ

MENSHO X — RAFFLES PLACE

Opened 14 July: the global debut of a fast-casual spin-off from Tokyo's Mensho (chef Tomoharu Shono), with a menu exclusive to this outlet — toripaitan ramen, tsukemen, mochi-mochi mazemen, everything under S\$22. CBD lunch queues at peak but short waits before six; strong early social pickup on a "Michelin-brand ramen for under \$20" line. Not halal.

Verdict: the value pick of the month ·

TOKYO IMPORT

UNDER S\$22

SUKIYAKI JIN — SHAW CENTRE

Still hot from a May open: Les Amis Group's casual sukiyaki house (from the Shabu Jin / Wagyu Jin stable) and Singapore's first spicy-tomato sukiyaki broth. A5 wagyu from about S\$45 a head, S\$90 the pot for two; Time Out and Honeycombers both ran "is it worth it?" verdicts, the wagyu praised, the twelve-to-fourteen-slice portions the recurring debate. Positioned as premium without the prohibitive. Not halal.

Verdict: worth it if wagyu is the point · **WAGYU**

LES AMIS

ALSO OPENING · IN BRIEF

Blue Bottle Coffee (Paragon) — a second Orchard outlet for the third-wave chain; solid early Eatbook and HungryGoWhere pickup, though sources differ on whether it is the region's first standalone café, so we flag rather than assert.² **Rotation note:** La Saigon Café (No. 48) is rested this issue — no new peg.

SOURCES ¹ Ticketmaster Singapore; Harper's Bazaar SG; Honeycombers concert listings, 2026. ² Time Out SG, 13 Jul 2026; Eatbook; HungryGoWhere, Jul 2026 (Blue Box, MENSCHO X, Sukiyaki Jin, Blue Bottle — buzz summarised; Blue Bottle "standalone" framing unverified).

JAPAN

THE AUTUMN CALENDAR

13–27 SEP ★ **Aki Basho — Grand Sumo Autumn Tournament, Ryogoku Kokugikan, Tokyo**
15-DAY TOURNAMENT · TICKETS RELEASED EARLY AUGUST · FINAL-DAY AND WEEKEND SEATS GO FIRST

17–21 SEP **Tokyo Game Show — Makuhari Messe**
30TH EDITION, A FIVE-DAY RUN FOR THE FIRST TIME · TWO TRADE DAYS, THREE PUBLIC · ~300,000 EXPECTED

22 OCT **Jidai Matsuri — Kyoto**
A 2,000-STRONG COSTUMED PROCESSION ACROSS A THOUSAND YEARS OF HISTORY · ONE OF KYOTO'S THREE GREAT FESTIVALS

This advances the autumn run first mapped in No. 47–48: once the summer matsuri close, the calendar goes straight to sumo, gaming and Kyoto's marquee procession. The travel angle is unchanged from p15 — a firm Singapore dollar against a still-soft yen (USD/JPY near 162.5) keeps the arithmetic in the Tokyo traveller's favour.¹

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

14–16 AUG **Björn Again — ABBA Forever, Sands Theatre, Singapore**
FROM S\$68 · A FAMILY-FRIENDLY NIGHT IN TOWN BEFORE THE SEPTEMBER RUSH

MID AUG **Summer Sonic — Osaka & Tokyo**
JAPAN'S BIG CITY FESTIVAL · PAIRS NATURALLY WITH AN EARLY-AUTUMN KANSAI SWING

6–15 OCT **Busan International Film Festival**
31ST EDITION, ASIA'S LARGEST · PAIRS WITH THE AUTUMN-FOLIAGE WINDOW FOR A KOREA-THEN-JAPAN SWING · SEE P12

14 SEP **Epica — Tokyo (Osaka 15 Sep)**
SYMPHONIC METAL FOR THE READER COMBINING THE SUMO BASHO WITH A LIVE NIGHT IN TOWN

25 NOV **Iron Maiden — Yokohama**
A RARE JAPAN DATE · BOOK FLIGHTS EARLY AGAINST THE AUTUMN-FOLIAGE TRAVEL PEAK

A single autumn Japan trip can now be built around almost any interest the reader holds — sumo and gaming in mid-September, three of the country's great processions through October, and live music bracketing both ends. The one constraint is the yen: the same softness that flatters the shopping (p11) flatters everyone else's plans too, so the good rooms in Tokyo and Kyoto go early.

PLANNING NOTES

September is the pinch. The Weeknd's two SG nights (p19), Aki Basho and Tokyo Game Show all fall inside three weeks — if you are combining a Tokyo trip with a home concert, lock accommodation on both ends now, before the sumo tickets release in early August pull the Tokyo inventory.

Family-friendly: Björn Again and the earlier days of the sumo basho travel best with an eleven-year-old; arena rap nights, less so.

STILL WORTH BOOKING

Belle & Sebastian (20 Sep, p19) is the seated option in a standing-heavy quarter.

Björn Again (14–16 Aug) is the low-stakes family night before the rush.

Summer Sonic (mid-Aug) pairs with a Kansai swing if the trip runs early.

THE HAND-OFF

This is where the book's travel thread lands each week: the Macro Desk sets the currency (p15), The Good Life the objects worth flying for (p11), and The Diary the dated events to actually book. On a weekday briefing there is no Grand Tour deep dive — that supplement runs only on the weekend — but the arithmetic it would use is the same one on every page here: a firm Singapore dollar, a soft yen, and an autumn calendar that rewards booking early over booking well.

THE LONG READ

Pricing the Unarrived

Half a billion trailer views, a Fed meeting not yet sat, a bid on empty land, a war premium on oil still flowing: this week was thick with prices for things that have not happened. Three episodes — a rice market, a bubble and a mania — about what a society is really doing when it buys the future.

Samuel Johnson, writing in *The Rambler* in the winter of 1751, put the whole business in nine words: "the future is purchased by the present."¹ He meant it morally — that lasting happiness is bought only by forbearing some pleasure now — but the sentence has a second life as a description of markets, calendars and hype, all of which do exactly what it says. They take something that has not arrived and give it a price today. This issue is unusually full of the practice. A trailer for a film that opens in 2027 drew 503 million views in a day and pulled \$16.5 million of presales for tickets to nothing yet screenable (p12). A Federal Reserve that will not meet until the 28th had its July decision repriced from a near-certain hold to a coin flip, on rhetoric alone (p15). A consortium staked S\$2.13 billion on Bedok land that will not house a soul for years (p6). And a war drove oil up a fifth on the fear of a strait closing, not the fact of one closed (p3).

Put together, they describe a civilisation that lives a surprising amount of its life in the future tense — and that has been doing so for far longer than the word "futures" has existed as a financial term. The instinct to buy and sell the unarrived is old, and the three best lessons about it are old too.

To trade the future you must first agree it is real enough to sell — and that agreement is where the trouble starts.

Begin in Osaka, in the rice cellars along the Dojima canal. By the early eighteenth century the merchants there had built something the world had not quite seen before: a market not in rice, but in *claims* on rice not yet delivered. Warehouse receipts for stored grain — *kome tegata*, rice bills — began to trade in their own right, and by 1730 the shogunate under

Tokugawa Yoshimune formally licensed the Dojima Rice Exchange, where standardised contracts on future rice were bought and sold, cleared through a rudimentary clearing house, and settled in cash.² Historians of finance call it the first organised futures market on record — a full century and a half before Chicago. Its genius was also its danger: it let a farmer lock in a price before harvest and a lord borrow against a crop still in the field, but it also let the price of rice float free of any actual rice, rising and falling on rumour, weather and the mood of the cellars. The bakufu spent decades alternately encouraging the exchange and trying to ban the speculation it produced, discovering the permanent paradox of the practice: the same mechanism that lets people manage the future's risk also lets them gamble on it.

The lesson of Dojima is not that trading the future is folly. It is that a futures price is a strange hybrid — part sober forecast, part collective feeling — and that the two are almost impossible to separate in the moment. The \$91 oil of this week is a Dojima price. Some of it is a real assessment of supply through two threatened straits; some of it is fear, priced. Nobody at the screen can tell you the ratio, and neither could anyone in Osaka.

If Dojima shows the mechanism working, London shows it breaking. In 1720 the South Sea Company — granted a monopoly on trade with Spanish America that it had almost no ability to exercise — persuaded a nation to swap solid government debt for its shares, on the strength of prospective riches that existed mainly in the prospectus.³ The share price went from £128 in January to roughly £1,000 by summer and back to £150 by autumn, ruining thousands, reportedly including Isaac Newton, who is said to have observed that he could calculate the motions of the heavenly bodies but not the madness of people.

SOURCES 1 Samuel Johnson, *The Rambler* No. 175 (19 Nov 1751). 2 Standard financial histories of the Dojima Rice Exchange, Osaka (formally licensed 1730 under Tokugawa Yoshimune); West, "Private Ordering at the World's First Futures Exchange," *Michigan Law Review* (2000). 3 Standard histories of the South Sea Bubble of 1720; the Newton attribution is traditional and not firmly documented.

What made the South Sea Bubble a bubble rather than a bad bet was not that the future it sold was uncertain — all futures are — but that the market stopped pricing the future at all and began pricing the rise. People bought at £700 not because they believed the company would earn £700 of value per share, but because they believed someone would pay £800 next week. The unrarried thing being traded was no longer Spanish-American trade; it was the next buyer's expectation of the buyer after that. Anticipation had detached from its object and begun feeding on itself. When a modern trailer's 503 million views become an argument for the film's success, it is worth asking which of the two things is being priced: the movie, or the next person's excitement about the movie. Disney is betting, rationally, that in a franchise economy the anticipation is a real asset — that hype compounds into opening weekend the way South Sea optimism was supposed to compound into dividends. Sometimes it does. The question the bubble leaves is how you tell the difference from inside it, and the honest answer is that you usually cannot.

The market stopped pricing the future and started pricing the rise. Anticipation had detached from its object and begun to feed on itself.

The third episode is the one that most resembles our own, because it got the future *right* and still ruined people. Britain's Railway Mania of the 1840s was built on a correct premise: railways were the transformative technology of the age, and the network being mapped across the country would indeed reshape the economy for a century.¹ Investors poured savings into hundreds of railway companies at soaring valuations. And then the ordinary future arrived — not a crash of the idea, but the plodding reality of construction costs, competition, and lines that took years to earn anything — and share prices collapsed by roughly half from their 1845 peak even

as the tracks were, in many cases, successfully laid.² The railways were real. The timing the prices implied was fantasy. Fortunes were lost not because the technology failed but because the market had discounted a decade of future into a single year of present, and the future declined to be hurried.

That is the trap most relevant this week, because it is the subtlest. Dojima teaches that a future price mixes forecast with feeling. The South Sea Bubble teaches that anticipation can detach from its object entirely. But Railway Mania teaches the hardest thing: that you can be completely right about *what* will happen and completely wrong about *when*, and that the gap between the two is where money and nerve are lost. The AI-chip tape that fell into a bear market this week (p7, p15) is a Railway Mania price. Almost no serious person doubts that the technology is transformative; what the market is thrashing out, violently, is the schedule — how fast the returns arrive, how quickly cheaper open models compress the premium, whether the spending pulls forward a future that then takes longer than the spreadsheet assumed. The bulls and bears are not really arguing about the destination. They are arguing about the discount rate.

And a discount rate, it turns out, is a moral instrument as much as a financial one. To discount the future is to decide how much less a thing is worth for not having arrived yet — and that decision governs far more than markets. A society that discounts the future steeply books its pleasures now and lets the bill mature elsewhere: it burns the oil, defers the maintenance, floods the calendar with things to anticipate because anticipation is cheaper and safer than arrival. A society that discounts it gently forbears — which is precisely the sense in which Johnson meant his line. "The future is purchased by the present" was, for him, a sentence about self-command: the willingness to pay now, in restraint, for something that will only show up later.

SOURCES 1 Standard economic histories of the British Railway Mania of the 1840s. 2 Odlyzko, "Collective hallucinations and inefficient markets: The British Railway Mania of the 1840s" (2010) — railway share index roughly halved from its 1845 peak.

Which returns us, finally, to the week's smaller prices, the ones that are not markets at all. The Bedok land bid (p6) is a wager on the 2030s written in today's money — a discount rate made concrete, a bet that a coastal precinct will be worth building toward before anyone has laid a brick. The autumn concert squeeze on p19 is the ordinary version everyone practises: booking a September night in July, paying now for a pleasure held in escrow, purchasing the future by the present in the most literal way Johnson could have meant. Even the interstellar comet on p16 is a kind of arrival long anticipated — the third of its kind we have ever managed to catch, extraordinary precisely because it comes once and does not return, the opposite of everything a futures market trades. You cannot buy a claim on 3I/ATLAS. It simply arrives, is briefly present, and is gone — which may be why a passing comet still moves people in a way a repricing never will.

The comet is the opposite of a futures contract: it cannot be bought, only awaited — and it arrives exactly once.

The three episodes do not add up to a warning against pricing the future; that would be a warning against finance, calendars and hope itself, and it would be silly. They add up to something more useful — a way of reading a week like this one. When you see a price on something unrarrived, ask the Dojima question first: how much of this is forecast and how much is feeling? Then ask the South Sea question: is the thing itself being priced, or only the next person's expectation of it? And then ask the Railway question, which is usually the one that matters: even if this is right, is it right yet — or has a decade of future been folded into a single year of present, waiting to be disappointed by the calendar?

None of the week's prices is obviously foolish. A war premium on oil is rational when two straits are threatened. A bid on Bedok is rational for a builder with a twenty-year horizon. Even 503 million views is a rational asset in an economy where attention converts to money. What the three histories counsel is not abstention but humility about the number — a memory that every price on the unrarrived is a sentence written in the future tense, and that the future has a long record of declining to be dictated to. Johnson's line survives because it holds both halves at once: you really can purchase the future by the present, in restraint or in speculation. What you cannot do is set the terms of delivery. That part arrives on its own schedule, indifferent to what you paid — a comet on its own orbit, a harvest in its own season, a film in its own year, a rate decision in its own room on the 28th.

Which is, in the end, what Johnson was after. His sentence is not a warning against buying the future; it is an instruction about *how*. Purchase it with the present — with attention, with restraint, with a clear head about what you are actually paying for — and you have a chance of getting the thing you meant to. Purchase it with the present's fever, its crowd, its certainty that the number can only go up, and you will still get a future; it just will not be the one on the ticket. The week's prices will resolve, one by one, on the calendar's terms and not ours: the Fed will sit, the film will open, the ground at Bedok will or will not be worth what someone staked on it, the comet will round the Sun and leave. All we get to decide is how we hold the wait.

THE THREADS

Running through No. 49: a war priced on fear of a closed strait (p3); an AI-chip tape fighting over timing, not destination (p7, p15); a record land bid on the 2030s (p6); a trailer worth half a billion views before a frame is sold (p12); a comet that can only be awaited, never bought (p16). One habit — pricing the unrarrived — read five ways.

So much of the week was spent on things that had not happened yet — a trailer for next year, a rate meeting next week, a bid on the next decade, a war premium on a strait still open. We are very good at pricing the future and very bad at setting its schedule. The one arrival this issue that could only be awaited, not bought — a comet passing once and never again — is the one that moved people most. There may be a lesson in that.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 49

The World: NPR, The War Zone, Daily Caller, Just Security, CNN, Al Jazeera, Press TV/IRNA, Reuters, Ukrinform, Ukrainska Pravda, WHO, ECDC, Washington Times, Democracy Now, AFP, Fortune, Breitbart.

Singapore / Property: Judiciary/PMO, Mothership, The Straits Times, The Online Citizen, Enterprise Singapore, SMU Newsroom, MAS, Yahoo Finance SG, EdgeProp, The Edge Singapore, Stacked Homes, 99.co, URA, HDB, Malay Mail, HardwareZone.

Technology: Forbes, CompaniesMarketCap, SiliconANGLE, Nvidia Newsroom, CNBC, Bloomberg, BigGo Finance, Astute Group, China Briefing, MarkTechPost, interconnects.ai, TechNode, TrendForce, Notebookcheck, Ollama.

The Kit / Connected Home: Samsung Newsroom, SamMobile, PhoneArena, AndroidHeadlines, Android Authority, TechTimes, TechRadar, home-assistant.io, Matter Alpha, MacRumors, matter-smarthome.de.

Good Life / Screen & Sound: What Hi-Fi?, TrustedReviews, Forbes, The Art Newspaper, Sotheby's, Variety, ComicBook.com, ABC News, Deadline, WORLD

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Macro: TradingEconomics, Fortune, Bloomberg, CME FedWatch, Kalshi, Polymarket, Vantage Markets, MTFX, StockAnalysis.com, Investing.com, iShares, CNBC Select, JM Bullion, Sunday Guardian.

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Diary / Table: Ticketmaster SG, Harper's Bazaar SG, Honeycombers, Time Out SG, Eatbook, HungryGoWhere, JNTO, Nihon Sumo Kyokai, Songkick, Japan Travel.